

# Democracy's Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84-355] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 21, 2026

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Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern

Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)

**CMU Academic Calendar**

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**: <https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html>

**Course Relevance:** DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas

**Prerequisites:** 36-200 Reasoning with Data

## August

| S  | M  | T  | W  | T  | F  | S  |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|
|    |    |    |    |    |    | 1  |
| 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  | 6  | 7  | 8  |
| 9  | 10 | 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 | 15 |
| 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 | 20 | 21 | 22 |
| 23 | 24 | 25 | 26 | 27 | 28 | 29 |
| 30 | 31 |    |    |    |    |    |

## September

| S  | M  | T  | W  | T  | F  | S  |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|
|    |    | 1  | 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  |
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| 13 | 14 | 15 | 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 |
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## October

| S  | M  | T  | W  | T  | F  | S  |
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|    |    |    |    | 1  | 2  | 3  |
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| 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 | 15 | 16 | 17 |
| 18 | 19 | 20 | 21 | 22 | 23 | 24 |
| 25 | 26 | 27 | 28 | 29 | 30 | 31 |

## November

| S  | M  | T  | W  | T  | F  | S  |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|
| 1  | 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  | 6  | 7  |
| 8  | 9  | 10 | 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 |
| 15 | 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 | 20 | 21 |
| 22 | 23 | 24 | 25 | 26 | 27 | 28 |
| 29 | 30 |    |    |    |    |    |

## December

| S  | M  | T  | W  | T  | F  | S  |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|
|    |    | 1  | 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  |
| 6  | 7  | 8  | 9  | 10 | 11 | 12 |
| 13 | 14 | 15 | 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 |
| 20 | 21 | 22 | 23 | 24 | 25 | 26 |
| 27 | 28 | 29 | 30 | 31 |    |    |

■ in person

☒ remote

☐ no class

**25 meetings**, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. The tinted days are closures — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

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## 01 Course Description

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The point of this course is to understand the political world — particularly through the data it produces. American elections generate an enormous amount of it: vote returns reaching back to the nineteenth century, the census that decides how many seats each state gets, campaign finance filings, polls, roll-call votes, and the record of who turned out and who did not. Every one of those numbers was produced by somebody, for a purpose, and every one of them leaves something out.

We work with real data every week — 41 presidential elections since 1864, the apportionment that followed the 2020 census, FEC filings, congressional roll calls, Census and American Community Survey estimates, and the 2026 midterms as they happen. Tuesdays are for the week's reading and the argument it raises; Thursdays are for the data, worked through together.

**This is a general education course and there is no coding prerequisite.** Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you. What you are asked to do is read it closely, follow how the numbers were made, and explain what you are looking at. The skill being built is not programming; it is judgment about evidence. You will practise it on a data-driven news story written for real readers, and defend it in class every week.

## 02 Course Goals

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This course has one central aim: that you leave able to **look at a number about American democracy and know what to ask of it**. Who produced it, what it counts, what it leaves out, and whether it supports the claim being made in its name.

Everything else — the readings, the labs, the project — serves that.

## 03 Learning Objectives

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By the end of the semester you will be able to:

1. **Explain where American election data comes from** — who produces it, at what geographic level, and what each source does and does not capture. *(Units I and V)*
2. **Read a table, chart, or map of electoral data and say plainly what it shows, what it does not show, and what would have to be true for its conclusion to hold.** *(every unit; this is the core skill)*

3. **Test a claim about elections against the underlying data** — whether the claim comes from a news story, a campaign, or a scholarly argument. *(Units II and III)*
4. **Explain the institutions that convert votes into power**: the Electoral College, apportionment, districting, and the Voting Rights Act. *(Units I, IV, V)*
5. **Recognise when a number misleads** — through selective framing, mismatched units of analysis, or a model that gets the right answer for the wrong reason. *(every unit)*
6. **Write about quantitative evidence for a non-technical audience** — in journalistic form at length, and briefly every week on the discussion board. *(the data journalism project; the board)*

Each unit below states which of these it is building. If at any point you cannot tell why we are doing something, that is a failure of my design and not of your attention — please say so, and I will fix it.

## 04 Grading

Your grade rests on engagement as much as on output. The course is built around two things happening every week — you arriving having read, and you arriving having found data — and neither can be made up afterwards.

**Deadlines.** You are expected to meet them. If you can see in advance that you will not, contact me **before** the due date and we will sort something out.

Late work loses **one percentage point per hour, and never falls below 50%**.<sup>1</sup> Canvas applies this automatically. Submit what you have rather than polishing something that is already late.

Work that is never submitted scores **zero**, which is the whole reason the late floor sits at 50%: handing something in a week late is always worth more than handing in nothing.

Two things sit outside that rule because being late breaks somebody else's work, not just your own:

- **Peer reviews.** Your classmate cannot revise against a review that has not arrived. Late reviews are marked down sharply.
- **Project drafts.** A missing draft means two people have nothing to review, and — as above — you cannot rescue a missing draft with a good final.

<sup>1</sup> An hour or two costs almost nothing; a day costs a letter grade. Charging by the hour rather than the day removes the cliff at midnight — being twenty minutes late should not cost the same as being twenty hours late. The floor is there so that late work is always worth more than no work.

## 05 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

| Category                              | Percent of Final Grade |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>Participation &amp; Attendance</b> | 23%                    |
| <b>Discussion Board</b>               | 10%                    |
| <b>Surveys</b> (3, completion only)   | 2%                     |

| Category                         | Percent of Final Grade |
|----------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>Weekly Data Contributions</b> | 10%                    |
| <b>Three Tests</b> (10% each)    | 30%                    |
| <b>Data Journalism Project</b>   | 25%                    |

What each one is:

- **Participation & Attendance** — Being here, prepared, and in the conversation — on both days.
- **Discussion Board** — By Friday night each week, one post about any of the data we talked about: the lab, a classmate's data slide, a figure in the reading. Something that surprised you, something we missed, something you do not understand, or an answer to somebody else's question. **A few sentences to a paragraph** — enough to show you engaged with what we did. One post is full credit.
- **Surveys** — Three short ones: the **Cervas Election Study** in Week 1, a **midterm feedback** survey once you have seen how the course actually runs, and the **course evaluation** at the end. Graded for completion only — there are no right answers, and nothing you say affects any other part of your grade.
- **Weekly Data Contributions** — Find data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, name the source, and post it as a slide before Thursday. Each week two slides are drawn at random and worked through in class, and nobody presents the data they found themselves — expect your own data to come up once or twice all term. The slide is marked complete or incomplete each week. At the end of term you hand in a **newsletter**: every piece of data you found, each with a short write-up. **Build it as you go** — it is a paragraph a week, and an evening's work if you leave it all to December.
- **Three Tests** — In class, on paper, and **on the textbook only**. Test 1 on **Thu, Oct 8** (Sides et al., Chapters 1–5), Test 2 on **Tue, Nov 10** (Chapters 6–9), Test 3 on **Thu, Dec 3** (Chapters 10–13). We read the book straight through in its own order, so each test is a block of consecutive chapters: each covers the chapters read since the last one, **none is cumulative**, and every chapter appears on exactly one test. There is no final exam.
- **Data Journalism Project** — A data-driven news story about a trend or issue in electoral processes. Runs in three parts — draft, peer review, final — and **most of the marks are on the first two**. It is the only substantial piece of writing this term.

## 06 Due Dates

| Assignment  | Due                                                                                                                      |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Data slide  | before <b>each Thursday</b>                                                                                              |
| Surveys (3) | <b>Wed, Aug 26</b> (Cervas Election Study), <b>Fri, Oct 23</b> (midterm feedback), <b>final week</b> (course evaluation) |

| Assignment                                      | Due                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Discussion board post                           | <b>Friday, 11:59 p.m.</b> , each week                                       |
| Data Session 4 board post (no Thursday session) | <b>Tue, Sep 22</b> — no session to follow that week, so you get the weekend |
| Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)               | <b>Mon, Nov 30</b> — Tuesday is on Zoom, and there is no Thursday           |
| <b>Test 1</b> — Ch. 1-5                         | <b>Thu, Oct 8</b> , in class                                                |
| Data journalism: pitch                          | <b>Tue, Oct 20</b> , in class                                               |
| <b>Test 2</b> — Ch. 6-9                         | <b>Tue, Nov 10</b> , in class                                               |
| Data journalism: <b>draft</b>                   | <b>Thu, Nov 19</b> — the last session before the break                      |
| Data journalism: <b>peer reviews</b> (two)      | <b>Tue, Dec 1</b>                                                           |
| <b>Test 3</b> — Ch. 10-13                       | <b>Thu, Dec 3</b> , in class                                                |
| Data newsletter                                 | <b>Fri, Dec 4</b> — the last day of classes                                 |
| Data journalism: <b>final</b>                   | <b>Fri, Dec 11</b> — after the last session                                 |

There is no final exam.

## 07 Required Text

John Sides, Daron Shaw, Matt Grossmann & Keena Lipsitz. *Campaigns and Elections*. New York: W. W. Norton. ISBN 978-1-324-11504-5.

Readings from the text provide the **context** for each week. Expect to read one chapter before Tuesday, when we discuss it, and to spend Thursday working with data — the weekly draw, then the lab. Chapters are short — budget about an hour.

There is nothing else to buy.

## Current events

**The textbook is the context; the news is the test.** A textbook chapter is settled by the time it prints, and this one went to press before the campaign you are living through. The point of this course is to understand the political world — above all through the data it produces — and a chapter alone cannot do that, because politics keeps happening after the book is finished.

We also happen to be meeting during a midterm cycle, which means the week's reading and the week's news will sometimes land on the same question. When that happens it is worth taking advantage of. It is a convenience, though, not the design: the reason to read a news story next to a chapter is that together they tell you more about how politics works than either does alone.

So most weeks carry **one or two short current-events items alongside the chapter** — a news article, an interactive, a newsletter post, sometimes a podcast episode. They are listed in the schedule below and posted on Canvas.

They are not optional and not background: they are usually what the Tuesday discussion actually argues about, because they are where the chapter's claim either holds up or does not.

**The schedule's links are a starting set.** A syllabus written in August cannot know what November will produce. Expect items to be added during the term, always to Canvas. If the schedule and Canvas disagree, Canvas is right.

**These are also where your weekly data slide comes from.** You are not expected to go hunting in unfamiliar places. Anything below is fair game, and so is anything else you can source and name.

|                              | Worth following all term                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>General</b>               | <i>New York Times</i> (especially The Upshot), <i>Washington Post</i> , <i>Wall Street Journal</i> — all three are free to you through the CMU Libraries                   |
| <b>Elections specialists</b> | Bolts, Votebeat, Stateline, Democracy Docket, Cook Political Report, Sabato's Crystal Ball                                                                                 |
| <b>Data and forecasting</b>  | Strength In Numbers (G. Elliott Morris), Silver Bulletin, Split Ticket, The Downballot                                                                                     |
| <b>Podcasts</b>              | <i>The Ezra Klein Show</i> (NYT) · <i>NPR Politics Podcast</i> · <i>The Downballot</i> (weekly, Thursdays) · <i>Amicus</i> (Slate) · <i>Public Opinion Podcast</i> (AAPOR) |

Where a specific episode is assigned it appears in the schedule marked **Podcast:**, the same way readings and labs are marked. Five weeks carry one.

None of these is required reading in itself. Pick two or three and actually follow them; that is worth more than skimming all of them once.

## 08 What you need

**This is not a programming course, and there is no coding prerequisite.**

There is no software to install and nothing to set up. Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief — the source, the decisions behind it, and the figures already made — and your job is to read it, follow how the numbers were built, and above all *explain what you are looking at*. If you have never worked with data before, you are exactly who these labs are written for.

What you are graded on is the thinking, not the typing. Nothing you hand in this term asks you to produce code or a chart — what you hand in is what you made of what the data shows.

Bring a laptop to Thursday sessions if you have one; the briefs are web pages and they read well on a phone or on paper too. If you would rather work from a printout, say so and I will bring one.

## 09 How This Course Works

The same rhythm every week. Nothing in the schedule should ever surprise you.

**Tuesday is for the reading. Thursday is for data.**

| When                              | What                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Before Tuesday</b>             | Read the week's chapter — about an hour.                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Tuesday, in class</b>          | The chapter: what it claims, what it shows, who disputes it, and what would settle it.                                                                     |
| <b>Before Thursday</b>            | Post a data slide bearing on the question we ended Tuesday with.                                                                                           |
| <b>Thursday, in class</b>         | The data draw (first 15 minutes), then the lab. We work through it together; submit what you have at the end of class, which also records your attendance. |
| <b>Thursday evening or Friday</b> | Post once to the discussion board about any of the data we talked about that week. Due <b>Friday, 11:59 p.m.</b>                                           |

**Every week ends with a post to the discussion board, due Friday, 11:59 p.m.,** the day after we work through data together. The deadline is close on purpose: reflect while it is still fresh, not four days later when all you remember is that there was a table.

**A few sentences to a paragraph.** What the post has to do is show that you were in the room and thinking about what was on the screen — name the number, the slide, or the finding you mean, and say what you make of it. A short post that does that beats a long one that could have been written by somebody who never turned up.

Write about **any of the data we talked about that week.** Usually that will be Thursday's lab, because it is what we spent the most time on. But a classmate's data slide from the draw, or a chart in the week's reading, or a number in one of the news items is equally fair game — if we looked at it together, you can write about it.

**One post is all it takes.** Do any *one* of these:

- **Something that surprised you.** A number that was not what you expected. Say what you expected and why, then what the data actually showed.
- **Something we missed.** A question the lab did not ask, a comparison it did not make, a group or a year it left out. You do not have to answer it — noticing it is the contribution.
- **Something you do not understand.** Genuinely. Not a performance of confusion: a real question about what a number means or why a method works. These are the most useful posts on the board and they are graded as generously as any other.
- **Or answer somebody.** Replying to a classmate counts as your post for the week, and a good answer is worth as much as a good question.

That last one matters. A board where everybody asks and nobody answers is not a discussion. If you know something, say so.

**No code, no charts, no screenshots.** Write what you made of what you saw.

## Tuesday: the reading

Tuesday has as much shape as Thursday does. We make the same four moves every week, in this order, and by the end of the hour we have turned a chapter into a question that data could answer.

|                            |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1. The claim</b>        | <i>15 min</i> | What is this chapter actually asserting? We put one sentence on the board and argue about the wording until it says something that could be wrong. "Campaigns matter" is not a claim. "Campaign spending changes vote share in House races" is.                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>2. The evidence</b>     | <i>20 min</i> | What does the chapter offer in support — a number, a study, a case, an anecdote, or nothing at all? Textbooks state a great many things without showing you why. Finding the unsupported sentences is not a criticism of the book; it is the exercise.                                                                                                                              |
| <b>3. The disagreement</b> | <i>30 min</i> | Who disputes this, and on what grounds? Each Tuesday names two of the four standards from Chapter 1 — free choice, political equality, deliberation, free speech — and a question that forces you to trade one against the other. The reference sheet at the end of this syllabus explains all four. We take sides — you will often be asked to argue the position you do not hold. |
| <b>4. The test</b>         | <i>15 min</i> | What evidence would settle it? We end by writing down one question that data could answer.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

**Move 4 is the handoff.** The question we end Tuesday with is the prompt for the data you post before Thursday. You are not hunting for something interesting in the abstract; you are looking for evidence bearing on a question the room agreed was worth asking two days earlier — and on Thursday we find out whether anybody could.

**What to bring on Tuesday.** The chapter, read, and **one sentence in it you would want to see tested.** You will not hand that in, and I may ask you for it.

## 10 Structure of the Course

The course has three layers, and every week runs all three.

| Layer                  | Where                                     | The question it answers                        |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Prepared data</b>   | your weekly data slide, and the draw      | <i>What is being claimed?</i>                  |
| <b>Underlying data</b> | <b>Thursday's data session</b>            | <b><i>Where did that number come from?</i></b> |
| <b>Why it matters</b>  | Tuesday's chapter, and Thursday's reading | <i>Why should anyone care?</i>                 |

**The loop is the point.** You bring a chart on Tuesday. On Thursday we open the file it was built from and find out what had to be decided, discarded or guessed to produce it. The readings tell you why anyone bothered.

**Tuesdays** are for the chapter and the argument it raises. **Thursdays** are one source of data, start to finish — the weekly draw, then the lab.

### The data sessions

**They come in three parts, and the parts are a claim about who collected the data and why.** The state **enumerates**, and you are required by law to answer (I). Somebody **asks**, and you answer because you feel like it (II). Then an election happens, and Part III is everything it leaves behind: the state **certifies** the result and **administers** the machinery that produced it, a candidate **discloses** because a statute compels it, an ordinary person is in the file having been asked nothing at all, and where nobody collected anything a researcher **built** the number.

| Pt                                           | Sessions    |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------|
| I    The Census Bureau                       | <b>1-3</b>  |
| II   Surveys                                 | <b>4-6</b>  |
| III   Elections, and the records around them | <b>7-12</b> |

Which source each Thursday takes is set week by week in the schedule below, not here — the part is the promise, the particular file is not.

**The order is cumulative: nothing is inferred from a source you have not already met.** The census (Part I) comes before the districts drawn on top of it. Surveys (II) come before the models built out of them. Returns (III) come before we ask who cast them, and the voter file — the other half of the same part — comes before we guess race from it. By the last sessions you are being asked to judge a number rather than read one, which only works because you already know where every part of it came from.

**Session 10 is fixed to Nov 5** and is the only session whose date is not ours to choose: it runs on returns that do not exist until Nov 3, and everything around it is arranged to suit.

**The textbook runs on its own track** — not tied to the parts. We read it straight through, Chapters 1 to 13, and the three tests are the blocks that fall between: Ch. 1-5, Ch. 6-9, Ch. 10-13. They cover the textbook and nothing else.

**The book's own briefs turn up in class.** The book being built for this course is made of short written walkthroughs — one file, one chart, ten numbered steps, no code. They are teaching material rather than homework: which one a session uses is decided on the day, mostly on Thursdays. Nothing to read in advance, nothing to install.

## 11 Assignment Details

### 1. Current Events Data Snippets

Every week you find a piece of data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, and bring it to class. Some weeks yours will be what the room works on. which weeks in advance.

**Before Thursday.** Post one slide to the shared deck (link on Canvas):

- **The data** — a figure, a chart, a table, a map. It can be one number or a hundred.
- **The source**, named and linked — not “a study,” but who published it
- **One sentence** on what you think it shows
- **Where you got it**, if you did anything to it — cropped a chart, took one row out of a table, converted a count into a percentage. Say so.

**It has to bear on the question we ended Tuesday with.** Every Tuesday closes by writing down one question that data could answer — that is move 4 of *Tuesday: the reading*, above. Your slide is your attempt at evidence for it. Read the question broadly; an odd angle is welcome. But do not bring turnout data to a week that ended on a question about the media.

That constraint is the point. When a dozen people go looking at the same subject, **they come back with data that disagree**, and working out why is most of what this course is about. You will not have to manufacture the disagreement. It arrives on its own.

**Example.** *Voter turnout*: “About two-thirds (66%) of the voting-eligible population turned out for the 2020 presidential election.” — Pew Research Center

Note the phrase “voting-eligible population.” Somebody else will arrive with turnout data built on a different denominator, and the two will not match. Neither of them is wrong.

**What the groups discuss.** The same three questions every week — the questions this whole course is about:

1. **What does it measure?** Who produced this, what exactly does it count, and what does it leave out?
2. **Does anyone else's data bear on it?** Agree, disagree, complicate. If two of you have data about the same thing that do not match, stop and work out why — that is the best thing that can happen in this exercise.
3. **How would you put it in a couple of sentences** to somebody who had not seen it?

Question 3 is not decoration. It is the rehearsal for explaining the data to the room, and if your group cannot answer it, the presenter is about to find that out in front of everyone.

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**In class Thursday — about fifteen minutes, before the lab.**

|                                  | What happens                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. <b>Before class</b>           | I draw <b>two names</b> . Those two slides are on the screen when you walk in.                                                                           |
| 2. <b>Four groups</b>            | We split into four groups. Two groups take the first piece of data, two take the second.                                                                 |
| 3. <b>The discussion</b> (7 min) | Each group works its data using the three questions above. Anyone whose own data bears on it brings it in.                                               |
| 4. <b>The second draw</b>        | Once discussion ends, I draw <b>one presenter for each piece of data</b> — from one of the two groups that worked it.                                    |
| 5. <b>The floor</b> (6 min)      | Each presenter explains data, and what their group talked about. Then the <b>other groups</b> say where they read it differently. Anyone can contribute. |

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**The two draws happen at different times, on purpose.**

The first is made after the submission deadline and before class, so that the slides are already up and I have had a chance to read them. You will not know whose data we are working on until you walk in — and since you posted yours before I drew, that cannot affect what you brought.

The second is made **live, after the discussion is over**. Nobody knows who is presenting while the group is still talking, so the only safe strategy is to understand your group's data well enough to explain it yourself. Everybody prepares; two people speak.

Names are **not put back**. Once your name is drawn it stays out until "the cup" is empty and I "refill" it.

**Nobody presents data they found themselves.** If you cannot restate somebody else's data accurately, you did not understand it.

**Why two groups take the same data.** So that we can see two honest readings of an identical thing side by side. When the second group says "we read that differently," that is not a failure by either group. It is the most useful two minutes of the exercise.

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**Grading.** The slide is marked complete/incomplete each week. There is no separate penalty for being drawn without one: a missing slide costs that week's credit, whether or not your name comes out.

What being drawn costs is not points. When your name comes out, the next fifteen minutes of the class are built on your having done a small piece of work. If you are not ready, I draw again and we carry on — but a room of nineteen people has been left waiting on you, and that is the reason to have something ready rather than a number in the gradebook. Over a semester you can expect your own data to be drawn once or twice, and to present somebody else's about as often.

**At the end: the newsletter.** Your weekly contributions do not evaporate once the class has discussed them. In the last week of term you hand in a single document — a **newsletter** — collecting every piece of data you found this semester, each with a short write-up: what it measures, where it came from, and what you made of it once the room had worked it over. A paragraph apiece is plenty.

|                      | Share of this component | What it is                                                         |
|----------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Weekly slides</b> | <b>70%</b>              | The data you post before each session, marked complete/incomplete. |
| <b>Newsletter</b>    | <b>30%</b>              | The collected set, written up, handed in at the end.               |

**Assemble it as you go.** The work is already done by the time you get there — you found the data, and the class told you what it was worth. Written up in the week it happened, each entry takes ten minutes; written up in December from a folder of half-remembered links, the whole thing is an evening you did not need to spend. **Due Fri, Dec 4, 11:59 p.m.**, the last day of classes.

It is worth a small share of the grade and it is the only place your own term's work sits in one piece. Several of these will be a better portfolio of what you can do with data than anything else you hand in.

## 2. Discussion Board

- We work through data together in class — the lab on Thursday, and before that the two slides drawn from the class. You submit what you have at the end of Thursday's session; this doubles as attendance.
- **Then you post that evening or the next day**, on the course discussion board in Canvas. Due **Friday, 11:59 p.m.** One post a week, and one post is all that is needed for full credit.
- **A few sentences to a paragraph.** What it has to do is show engagement with what we actually did in class. Say which number, slide or finding you mean and what you make of it. Running longer than a paragraph earns nothing on its own; running shorter usually means you have named something without saying what you make of it.
- **You are not asked to write code, and not asked to produce a chart.** The post is about what you made of the data.

Write about **any of the data we talked about that week** — the lab, a classmate's slide, a figure in the reading, a number in one of the news items. Do any one of these:

|                                        |                                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Something surprised you</b>         | Say what you expected and why, then what the data showed instead. The gap is the interesting part.                      |
| <b>Something we missed</b>             | A question nobody asked, a comparison nobody made, a group or a year left out. You need not answer it; noticing counts. |
| <b>Something you do not understand</b> | A real question about what a number means or why a method works. These are the most valuable posts on the board.        |
| <b>An answer</b>                       | Reply to a classmate. A good answer is worth as much as a good question, and counts as your post for the week.          |

Posts are graded on a four-point scale:

| Score    | What it looks like                                                                                                                                                                |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4</b> | Everything in a 3, plus something I did not ask for: a caveat about what the data cannot show, a connection to another week, or a question that sends the conversation somewhere. |
| <b>3</b> | A specific, well-supported point about the data — you name the number, you say what it means, and the reasoning holds. <b>This is the target. A 3 is good work.</b>               |
| <b>2</b> | On topic but unanchored: a reaction rather than an observation, or a point that does not rest on anything we actually looked at.                                                  |
| <b>1</b> | Generic enough that it could have been written without attending.                                                                                                                 |

**A confused question, asked precisely, is a 3.** Asking what you do not understand is not an admission that you fell behind — it is the most useful thing you can contribute, because if you are wondering it, so are six other people who have not said so.

A semester average of 75% earns an A–. Do not chase 4s; a consistent 3 is a strong grade.

### 3. The data journalism project

**A data-driven news story investigating a trend, pattern or issue in electoral processes**, written for somebody who does not read this sort of thing for pleasure. **2–4 pages, with at least two figures**, worked into the text rather than parked at the end. The full rubric is on Canvas.

**The figures do not have to be ones you built yourself.** A chart we made together in a lab is fine; so is a table you pull from data.census.gov, or a figure from one of the readings — provided you say what it shows, where it came from, and why it bears on your question. If you would rather make your own, the code in every lab is yours to adapt and I will help. **What is**

**graded is whether the evidence supports the claim**, not whether you wrote the plotting code.

One substantial piece of writing this term, worth **25%**, in three parts: a pitch in October, a full draft at the last session before the Thanksgiving break, and the revision after the term's final session. The reviews you write sit between the draft and the final, so the comments reach their author while there is still time to act on them.

|                    | Share of the project | What it is                                                                                                     |
|--------------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Pitch</b>       | <b>5%</b>            | One paragraph on <b>Tue, Oct 20</b> , in class. Marked for having done it.                                     |
| <b>Draft</b>       | <b>50%</b>           | A complete attempt – not an outline, not a sketch. Graded as though it were the finished piece.                |
| <b>Peer review</b> | <b>35%</b>           | The two reviews <b>you write</b> for other people. Graded on how useful they are to the person receiving them. |
| <b>Final</b>       | <b>10%</b>           | The revision. Graded on what you changed and why, not re-graded from scratch.                                  |

**Most of the marks are on the draft and the reviews, deliberately.** The usual way a paper gets written is that nothing happens for three weeks and then something happens the night before, and the comments you get back arrive too late to matter. So the draft has a deadline of its own – **Thu, Nov 19** – and carries 50% on that date, and the two reviews you write carry another 35% on **Tue, Dec 1**. **The piece has to be finished once, three weeks early, before it is finished for good.** A strong draft and two genuinely useful reviews will carry you even if the revision is modest. The corollary is that **the final is a small piece of the grade, and that is not an invitation to skip it.** Ten per cent is what a revision is worth when the work it revises was already done properly. It is not what the piece is worth. It also means **you cannot rescue a missing draft with a good final.** There is no version of this where the work starts late.

**On the peer review.** You will review two people's drafts, on a worksheet I provide, and they will review yours. What is graded is the review you *give*. A review that says "this is good, maybe add more data" is worth very little; a review that says "your second chart shows share and your argument needs counts, and I could not find where the 62% came from" is worth a great deal. Reviewing is a skill, it is most of what editors and referees actually do, and you will get better at your own writing by doing it.

**On the final.** Submit it with a short note – three or four sentences – on what you changed in response to the reviews and what you decided not to change and why. Declining to take advice is fine and sometimes right. Ignoring it silently is not.

#### 4. Tests

Three, in class, on paper, **10% each**.

|               | When               | Covers                  |
|---------------|--------------------|-------------------------|
| <b>Test 1</b> | <b>Thu, Oct 8</b>  | Sides et al., Ch. 1-5   |
| <b>Test 2</b> | <b>Tue, Nov 10</b> | Sides et al., Ch. 6-9   |
| <b>Test 3</b> | <b>Thu, Dec 3</b>  | Sides et al., Ch. 10-13 |

**All three cover the textbook only** – not the labs, not the outside readings, not the data sessions. Each one covers the chapters assigned since the previous test, and none is cumulative.

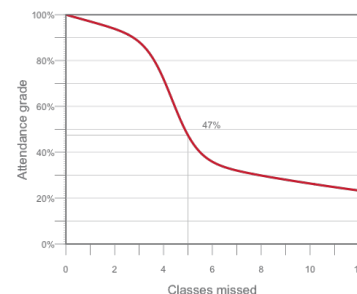
**We read the book straight through, 1 to 13.** There is nothing to keep track of: the chapters arrive in the book's own order, each test is the block read since the last one, and every chapter is read once and tested once. The book's internal references also come out right this way – Ch. 10 and 11 point back to campaign finance in Ch. 4, and several chapters point back to parties in Ch. 6, and you will have read both by the time they do. The questions come from the publisher's test bank: multiple choice and short answer, on what the chapters say. This is the one part of the course that rewards ordinary studying, and it exists because the rest of the course grades interpretation, which is harder to prepare for by reading carefully. If you have kept up with the chapters, no separate preparation should be needed.

**There is no final exam.** Test 3 is an ordinary class session in the last week, not a cumulative exam: it covers Chapters 10-13 and nothing before them.

**The data sessions are not tested.** Twelve of them – the census, precinct returns, voter files, election administration, campaign finance, surveys, polls, roll calls, cast vote records, redistricting – and none of it is on a test, because none of it is in the textbook. It is assessed the way the rest of the course is assessed: by what you say in the room and what you post to the board. Do not read "not on the test" as "not important." **It is the half of the course the course is named after.**

#### 5. Attendance:

Regular attendance and active involvement form a significant part of your final grade (see grading section). If you do not show up, you will not earn an 'A'. Participation is not just about being present; it involves engaging with the material, contributing to discussions, and collaborating with your peers. To recognize that occasional absences are sometimes unavoidable (e.g., for religious observance, job interviews, university-sanctioned events, or illness), attendance grades follow a curve with three stretches. The first three absences cost you almost nothing – that is what they are there for. From the fourth to the sixth the penalty bites hard, and this is the range where a semester goes wrong. After that the curve flattens into a long tail: each further absence still costs you, but less, and it never reaches zero. There is no point at which you may as well stop coming.



Absences and the attendance grade. The first three cost almost nothing; four to six is where it bites.

|                  |      |     |     |     |     |     |     |     |
|------------------|------|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| Classes missed   | 0    | 2   | 3   | 4   | 5   | 6   | 8   | 12  |
| Attendance grade | 100% | 94% | 88% | 72% | 47% | 36% | 30% | 23% |

If you must miss class, please notify me at least 24 hours in advance (unless it is an emergency or sudden illness) so we can arrange a way for you

to catch up.<sup>2</sup>

<sup>2</sup> If you need to miss more than two sessions due to extenuating circumstances, let me know as soon as possible so we can discuss how best to support you.

## 6. Surveys (2%)

Three short surveys, each graded purely for completion. There are no right answers, nothing you say is graded on content, and nothing you say affects any other part of your grade.

- **Week 1 – the Cervas Election Study.** Due **Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.** A survey instrument modelled on the Cooperative Election Study and the American National Election Study, but neither: items have been cut, reworded, and added. Your answers become a class dataset, which I report back in aggregate and never individually. We set it against the real Cooperative Election Study in **Session 6**.
- **Mid-term – course feedback.** Due **Fri, Oct 23, 11:59 p.m.**, after the first test and the break, which is late enough that you have seen how the course actually runs and early enough that I can still change it.
- **Final week – the course evaluation.**

The first survey is anonymous: it asks no name, requires no login, and records nothing that identifies you – which also means it cannot tell me you completed it. So credit runs on a receipt: **after you submit, screenshot the confirmation screen and upload it to the Canvas assignment.** The screenshot is your receipt; the survey data never learns who you are.

## 12 Schedule

Classes meet Tuesday and Thursday, 11:00a–12:20p, in PH A21A. Tuesdays are for the chapter and the question it raises; Thursdays open with the data draw and then run the lab. Read the assigned chapter **before** Tuesday, and post your data slide **before** Thursday. Your board post is due **Friday, 11:59 p.m.**

Subject to change as the semester progresses.

### How to read the schedule

*Every Thursday takes **one source of data** and goes behind a number you have already seen. Each session asks the same five questions – **what is one row? who made this, and why? how do you get it? what can it settle? what can it never settle?** – and each has its own reading, due before class, about that data.*

**The sessions come in three parts, and each part is a place data comes from.** Not a topic – a *source*. Turnout turns up four times in this course and means something slightly different each time, because a different organisation produced it for a different reason. Sorting by topic would hide that. Sorting by where it came from is what makes it visible.

**Part I is the Census Bureau**, one agency that counts people and places. It goes first because nearly every other part borrows a number from it: if you want to know what share of a county voted, somebody has to tell you how many people live there.

**Part II is surveys** — asking a sample of people questions and using the answers to describe everyone. You will already have met one in Part I, because the American Community Survey is a survey, and answering it is required by law. Here you meet the voluntary kind, and examine what goes wrong with them.

**Part III is elections, and everything that accretes around one.** The word is two things sharing a name: the **result** that officials certified, and the **machinery** that produced it — who was registered, who was removed, how many ballots were rejected.

Around that sit the records other people leave. A candidate **discloses** because a statute compels it: every campaign files what it raised, every member of Congress votes on the record, and the person in the row chose to run for office. An ordinary person leaves a record having volunteered nothing at all — a traffic stop, a jury summons, a grade stamped on a neighbourhood in 1937. And where nobody collected anything, a researcher **builds** the number. These sit in Part III because this is where they get used, and where nearly all the wrong answers live.

**The money runs early on purpose.** What a campaign files is taken in **Session 9**, one week before the election, while the campaign it describes is still running; what a member of Congress votes waits until Session 12. It also puts polls and forecasts (Session 5) and the money (Session 9) ahead of **election night (Session 10)**, so the night grades work you have already done.

**One session's date is not ours to choose.** **election-night** is a Part III session that runs on **Thu, Nov 5** and no other day, because it is built around returns that do not exist until Nov 3. Everything else is arranged around it: Sessions 7 and 8 through October, then the money session on **Oct 29** while the campaign is still running, then live returns on **Nov 5** and the machinery behind them on **Nov 12**. The arrangement earns its place — you met the midterm base rate in **Session 7** and you grade it on the night against what the country actually did.

**The book's own briefs turn up in class.** The book being built for this course is made of short written walkthroughs — one file, one chart, ten numbered steps, no code. They are teaching material rather than homework: which one a session uses is decided on the day, mostly on Thursdays. Nothing to read in advance, nothing to install.

**The textbook runs on its own track.** It is not tied to the parts. We read it **straight through, Chapters 1 to 13**, one or two chapters a week, and the three tests are simply the blocks that fall between them: **Ch. 1-5** on Oct 8, **Ch. 6-9** on Nov 10, **Ch. 10-13** on Dec 3. Nothing to keep track of, and the book's own cross-references land in the right order — Ch. 10 and 11 refer back to campaign finance in Ch. 4, and several chapters refer back to parties in Ch. 6, both of which you will already have read.

**The cost is worth naming.** A chapter no longer always sits beside the data session it feeds: you read campaign finance on **Sep 22** and do not touch FEC

filings until **Oct 29**. When a Thursday leans on a chapter you read weeks earlier, the session says so. **The three tests cover the textbook and nothing else.**

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## Week 1 – Part I opens

- **Tue, Aug 25** – Course introduction: the three layers. A number you read in the news, the file it came from, and the reason anyone cares. Then straight into the 2024 electoral map.
  - **The book's introduction – *What This Book Is For*** (about twenty minutes). Why every chapter here starts from the file rather than the question. Read it before Thursday; it is the argument the rest of the term is an argument with.
  - **Lab:** the 2024 electoral map. How to read one of these briefs.
  - **DUE Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.** – the **Cervas Election Study**, a survey instrument modelled on the Cooperative Election Study and the American National Election Study, but neither: items have been cut, reworded, and added. The link is in **Canvas, under Assignments**. You take it on your own time, before Thursday, because Thursday's session works with what the class answered. You are the sample. The survey is anonymous (no name, no login), so credit runs on a receipt: **screenshot the confirmation screen after you submit and upload it to the same Canvas assignment. We come back to your answers in Session 6**, when we set them against the real Cooperative Election Study.
- **Thu, Aug 27 – DATA SESSION 1 • Part I: The decennial census, and the seats it decides.** The one thing no other source in this course can do – count everybody, once, with no margin of error – how you get at it, and what the count is then used for: apportionment, and the seats each state gets.
  - U.S. Census Bureau, “America Counts: 250 Years,” <https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2026/06/america-counts-250-years.html>
  - Census Academy, “Introduction to the Census Bureau Data API” – **module 1 only**, <https://www.census.gov/data/academy/courses/intro-to-the-census-bureau-data-api.html>
  - NCSL, *Redistricting Law 2020, Ch. 1 (“The Census”)* – written by the chief of the Census Bureau's Redistricting and Voting Rights Data Office. On Canvas, and also public, [https://documents.ncsl.org/wwwncsl/Redistricting-Census/Redistricting-Law-2020\\_NCSL%20FINAL.pdf](https://documents.ncsl.org/wwwncsl/Redistricting-Census/Redistricting-Law-2020_NCSL%20FINAL.pdf)

## Week 2 – Part I

- **Tue, Sep 1** – The framework: what we are judging, and against what.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 1** – rules, reality, strategy, choice, and the four standards.

- James C. Scott, *Seeing Like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed* (Yale, 1998), Introduction – where the idea of a state making its population *legible* comes from. Ebook through the library, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1nq3vk>
- **Thu, Sep 3 – DATA SESSION 2 · Part I: Geography, and the scales it comes at.** Last week counted people. This week asks *where*, and discovers that the answer depends entirely on the size of the box you put them in.
  - U.S. Census Bureau, *Understanding Statistical Geographies* (webinar, video), <https://www.census.gov/library/video/2021/understanding-statistical-geographies.html> – where tracts, block groups and blocks came from, and how they have moved. The Bureau explaining its own containers, which is the thing this session takes apart.

### Week 3 – Part I

- **Tue, Sep 8** – The rules: who may vote, who may run, and how a population becomes seats.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 2** – who may vote, who may run, and how a population becomes seats.
  - Nate Cohn, “Republicans’ Electoral College Edge, Once Seen as Iron-clad, Looks to Be Fading,” *New York Times* (Upshot), <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/09/25/upshot/trump-electoral-college-harris.html>
  - Brennan Center, “Census Data Highlights a Changing Nation,” <https://www.brennancenter.org/our-work/research-reports/census-data-highlights-changing-nation>
  - “Black Representation in Congress at Risk after Court Ruling,” *NPR*, <https://www.npr.org/2026/04/30/nx-s1-5805050/supreme-court-voting-rights-congressional-black-caucus>
  - **Podcast: Amicus** (Slate), “A Huge Shift is Underway at SCOTUS” (Jun 13, 2026) – Pamela S. Karlan on *Callais* and *Milligan*, <https://slate.com/podcasts/amicus/2026/07/supreme-court-term-recap-birthright-citizenship-voting-rights>
- **Thu, Sep 10 – DATA SESSION 3 · Part I: The American Community Survey.** The census counts once a decade; the ACS asks a sample every year, and almost every current number about a place comes from it. A survey wearing the census’s clothes – with a margin of error the census does not have.
  - ACS Handbook, Ch. 1 – “Understanding the ACS: The Basics.” What the survey is, who it is built for, and the kind of question it exists to answer, [https://www.census.gov/content/dam/Census/library/publications/2020/acs/acs\\_general\\_handbook\\_2020\\_ch01.pdf](https://www.census.gov/content/dam/Census/library/publications/2020/acs/acs_general_handbook_2020_ch01.pdf)
  - Census Academy, *Discovering the American Community Survey* – **all six modules**, about ninety minutes of video in total, <https://www.census.gov/data/academy/courses/discovering-the-american-community-survey.html>

### Week 4 – Part II opens

- **Tue, Sep 15 – We meet.** The chapter, and the argument it raises.

- **Sides et al., Ch. 3** — the transformation of American campaigns.
- **Thu, Sep 17 — No class.** Constitution Day Symposium. Go if you can — it is the most on-topic thing happening on this campus all term.  
**DATA SESSION 4 · Part II: What a survey can establish, and how you get one.** Every source so far was a record of something that happened. This one is a record of what somebody *said*, and it can reach things no record can — at a price no sample size will buy off.
  - Pew Research Center, “How Public Polling Has Changed in the 21st Century” (April 2023), <https://www.pewresearch.org/methods/2023/04/19/how-public-polling-has-changed-in-the-21st-century/>
  - Pew Research Center, *Public Opinion Polling Basics* — lessons 1–3, <https://www.pewresearch.org/course/public-opinion-polling-basics/>
  - **Board post:** post any time before **Tue, Sep 22** — there is no Thursday session to follow this week, so you get the weekend.

### Week 5 — Part II

- **Tue, Sep 22** — Money, and the rule that shapes everything after it.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 4** — campaign finance.
- **Thu, Sep 24 — DATA SESSION 5 · Part II: Election polls, and what a margin hides.** The horse race: who is ahead, how that number is built, what weighting repairs, what it cannot, and why the misses of 2016 and 2020 were not bad luck. **This week is polls about an election.** Next week is the other kind of survey — the ones that ask what people think.
  - Michael A. Bailey, *Polling at a Crossroads: Rethinking Modern Survey Research* (Cambridge, 2023), **Ch. 1, pp. 3–22**. Cambridge Core, through the library, <https://www.cambridge.org/9781108482790>
  - “Are Political Polls Accurate?” *New York Times* (The Morning briefing, Aug 14, 2026), <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/08/14/briefing/are-political-polls-accurate.html>
  - **Podcast:** *Public Opinion Podcast* (AAPOR), “Pre-Election Polling: The Challenges and The Importance of Understanding the 2024 Voter” — Don Levy, <https://aapor.org/media/public-opinion-pod/>

### Week 6 — Part II closes

- **Tue, Sep 29** — Strategy: who a campaign decides to talk to, and how it decides.
  - Pascal Sabino, “Missourians Reject Measure That Threatened to Kill Citizen-Led Ballot Initiatives,” *Bolts*, August 5, 2026, <https://boltsmag.org/missouri-rejects-restrictions-on-direct-democracy/>
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 5** — campaign strategy and vote targets.
- **Thu, Oct 1 — DATA SESSION 6 · Part II: Public opinion, and the studies built to measure it.** Not who is ahead, but what people think — and how much of the answer is made by the question. You took the **Cervas Election Study** in Week 1; today it sits beside the two academic instruments it was modelled on and departs from. What can a class of eighteen establish that a national sample can, what can it not, and which differences are the instrument rather than the people?

- Sidney Verba, "The Citizen as Respondent: Sample Surveys and American Democracy," *American Political Science Review* 90(1), 1996, pp. 1-7 — **why we measure opinion this way at all**. Voting, giving and protesting all take resources, so they over-represent whoever has them; answering a survey takes none, which is why a survey can speak for people politics does not hear from. Seven pages, through the library, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2082793>
- Pew Research Center, "Writing Survey Questions" — then the how: wording, order effects, and response options, with examples of the same question measuring different opinions. Ten to fifteen minutes, <https://www.pewresearch.org/writing-survey-questions/>
- Reference: **Cooperative Election Study** — how it samples, and how many people it reaches, <https://cces.gov.harvard.edu/>
- Reference: **American National Election Studies** — the same two questions, answered a different way, <https://electionstudies.org/>
- Reference: Institute of Politics, Harvard Kennedy School, *Harvard Youth Poll*, 52nd edition — the topline, and the methodology statement behind them. **You are the population being sampled**, <https://iop.harvard.edu/youth-poll/52nd-edition-spring-2026>
- **Read Verba against Bailey from last week**. Verba's case for the survey rests on everyone being equally likely to answer. Bailey's chapter is about what happens when they are not. The whole of Part II sits in that gap.
- **No data slide and no draw this week.**

### Week 7 — Test 1

- **Tue, Oct 6** — Who the electorate is, and who gets asked about it.
  - **No new chapter this week**. You have read Ch. 1-5 and **Test 1 is Thursday**. Tuesday is the review — bring questions.
  - "Inside the Rise of the Multiracial Right," *New York Times* (Opinion), <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2025/07/24/opinion/minority-voters-trump-right.html>
- **Thu, Oct 8** — **TEST 1**, in class, on paper. **Sides et al., Ch. 1-5**.
  - Tuesday is the review, and fall break is the week after: the test does not sit across the break.
  - **In the time the test leaves**: nothing new.
  - **No data slide this week** — there is no data session to bring one to.

### Week 8 — FALL BREAK, no class (Oct 12-16)

Test 1 is behind you. Nothing is due.

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### Week 9 — Part III opens

- **Tue, Oct 20** — **DATA SESSION 7 • Part III opens: What a return is, where you get one, and what forty of them show**. Part III starts with the object itself. A return is a snapshot, and getting hold of one is harder than it sounds. Stack forty and you get a career, a base rate, and a way to be wrong about both.

- Alex Burness, “Election Data Is Vital to Voting Rights. So Why Is It So Hard to Track Down?” *Bolts*, <https://boltsmag.org/election-data-is-vital-to-voting-rights-but-hard-to-track-down/>
- FairVote, *Monopoly Politics 2026*, <https://fairvote.org/report/monopoly-politics-2026-update/> — a claim that **81% of 2026 House races are already decided**, published before anyone voted.
- **DUE: Data journalism story — pitch your topic** (one paragraph, in class).
- **Two data sessions this week, so two slides** — one before Tuesday and one before Thursday.
- **Thu, Oct 22 — DATA SESSION 8 • Part III: The bottom rungs — precincts and ballots.** Every session so far has used totals. Today we go down two rungs, to the smallest unit anybody publishes and then to the ballot itself.
  - Kate Murray, Samuel Baltz and Charles Stewart III, “Why Does Anyone Need Precinct-Level Election Results?” MIT Election Data and Science Lab — what a precinct is, what county totals lose, why the boundaries move between elections, and why you cannot read an individual off an aggregate. About fifteen minutes, <https://electionlab.mit.edu/articles/why-does-anyone-need-precinct-level-election-results>

## Week 10 — Part III

- **Tue, Oct 27** — Parties, and the groups that spend around them.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 6** — political parties.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 7** — interest groups.
- **Thu, Oct 29 — DATA SESSION 9 • Part III: Money in politics.** The record and the hole in it. Disclosure is the one source in this course written by the people it is about — self-reported like a survey, mandatory like a record — and it arrives one week before the country votes. Then the spending that never has to say where it came from.
  - OpenSecrets, “Dark Money Basics” — hard money and soft money, who has to name a donor and who does not, and roughly a billion dollars of spending since *Citizens United* that traces back to nobody, <https://www.opensecrets.org/dark-money/basics>
  - “Kamala Harris’s Donors,” *New York Times* (interactive) — skim the graphics. **This is what a disclosure file looks like once somebody draws it**, <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2024/08/22/us/elections/kamala-harris-donors.html>
  - “Donald Trump’s Campaign-Finance Disclosures Are ‘a Governance Nightmare,’” *New York Times* (Opinion) — the same instrument, read as a problem, <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/08/26/opinion/republican-donors-money-trump.html>
  - **Podcast: The Downballot** — an episode on the current cycle’s money, <https://www.the-downballot.com/podcast>
  - **A note on what we are not doing.** The obvious lab here would use the Meta and Google political ad libraries to show who was shown which ad. Both are effectively closed. **The most detailed record of political persuasion in America is not public**, and that absence is worth one minute of class time.

**Week 11 – Part III · election night**

- **Tue, Nov 3 – DEMOCRACY DAY / ELECTION DAY, no class before 5p.**
  - Read this week, for Thursday: **Sides et al., Ch. 8** (media) and **Ch. 9** (presidential campaigns).
- **Thu, Nov 5 – DATA SESSION 10 · Part III: Live returns.** (*Fixed date – the only session whose date is not ours to choose.*) The country voted on Tuesday. Today the numbers arrive while we watch, and we check them against everything that claimed to know in advance.
  - NPR, “Race calls 101: How the AP declares winners,” <https://www.npr.org/2024/11/05/g-s1-32603/how-are-races-actually-called> – short, and worth reading the morning of the session it describes. A call is a judgement about how much vote is left, not a result.
  - **Lab:** election night returns, live.

**Week 12 – Part III · the machinery**

- **Tue, Nov 10 – TEST 2**, in class, on paper. **Sides et al., Ch. 6–9.**
  - **Chapters 8 and 9 are on this test.** You read both last week, during the election.
- **Thu, Nov 12 – DATA SESSION 11 · Part III.** *Session and reading to be set.*

**Week 13 – Part III**

- **Tue, Nov 17** – The races down the ballot, and the careers they produce.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 10** – congressional campaigns.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 11** – state and local campaigns.
  - G. Elliott Morris, “The Hidden Axis: The Left-Right Spectrum Has a Non-Ideology Problem,” <https://www.gelliottmorris.com/p/not-just-left-vs-right-most-voters>
- **Thu, Nov 19 – DATA SESSION 12 · Part III.** *Session and reading to be set.*
  - **DUE: Data journalism DRAFT**, to Canvas before class. A complete attempt, graded as though it were the finished piece.

**Week 14 – the last two chapters**

- **Tue, Nov 24 – REMOTE – we meet on Zoom.** Link on Canvas. **The last two chapters.** Who turns out and who does not, and how the people who do decide. No data session this week, and no data slide – there is no Thursday to bring one to.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 12** – who participates, and who does not.
  - **Sides et al., Ch. 13** – vote choice.
  - Both are on **Test 3**, a week on Thursday.
- **Thu, Nov 26 – THANKSGIVING, no class**  
**Board post, this week only: due Mon, Nov 30, 11:59 p.m.** – not Friday.  
 There is no Thursday session to follow, and the Friday in question is the day after Thanksgiving.

**Week 15 – Part III, and the end**

- **Tue, Dec 1 — The end of the argument.** Where the term's questions land: the law, the maps, and whether the thing itself can be measured.
  - Don Moynihan, "Power, Democracy and Clarity," <https://open.substack.com/pub/donmoynihan/p/power-democracy-and-clarity> — the Court's voting-rights turn, and the maps redrawn after *Callais*.
  - Monmonier, *Drawing the Line*, Ch. 5 ("Boundary Litigation and the Map as Evidence"). Borrow it from the Internet Archive, <https://archive.org/details/drawinglinetales0000monm>
  - "Gerrymandered Districts Aren't Always Ugly," *New York Times* (Opinion, interactive) — a direct challenge to the eyeball test, <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2022/01/11/opinion/redistricting-gerrymandering-reform.html>
  - **Two ballot measures, two outcomes, one year.**
    - \* **California, Proposition 50** (passed Nov 4, 2025). Suspends the independent commission and uses a legislature-drawn congressional map from 2026 through 2030, <https://lao.ca.gov/BallotAnalysis/Proposition?number=50&year=2025>
    - \* **Virginia** (referendum Apr 21, 2026). A near-identical move, approved **50.7 to 49.3**, then **voided by the Supreme Court of Virginia on May 8, 2026**, 4–3, on a procedural question about early voting, <https://cardinalnews.org/2026/05/08/supreme-court-of-virginia-voids-redistricting-election-as-unconstitutional/>
  - **The last question: could you measure democracy itself?** We have spent twelve sessions measuring pieces of it — who is counted, who votes, who gives, who wins. **V-Dem** tries to score the whole thing, for every country, every year, with expert coders and uncertainty intervals around each estimate, <https://v-dem.net/>. Look at how it is built before you decide whether you believe it. It is a number somebody built, and you now know what to ask of one.
  - **If you want to draw a map yourself**, Dave's Redistricting is free and is what the professionals actually use — <https://davesredistricting.org>. Not assigned, not graded.
  - **DUE: peer reviews of the data journalism draft** — two each, worksheet on Canvas.
- **Thu, Dec 3 — TEST 3**, and the course wrap.
  - **TEST 3**, in class, on paper — **Sides et al., Ch. 10–13**. Nothing else is on it: not Tuesday's material, not the data sessions.
  - **Nothing to read**. Bring questions.

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- **DUE Fri, Dec 4 — the data newsletter:** every piece of data you contributed this term, each with a short write-up. You have been assembling it as you went, so this is a submission rather than a project.

**Finals period — there is no exam.** All three tests were held during the term, the last of them on Dec 3, and there is nothing to sit in the exam block. One deadline falls in it, and it is a deadline rather than an exam.

- **DUE Fri, Dec 11 — Data journalism story, final version**, with your note on what you changed. You wrote the draft before the break and revised it af-

ter the reviews came back; say what you changed and why. This is the last thing you owe me.

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## 13 AI Use Policy for Student Work

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As artificial intelligence (AI) tools become increasingly accessible, it is important to clarify expectations for their use in this course. You are welcome to use AI technologies (such as ChatGPT, Grammarly, or similar tools) to support your independent work—such as brainstorming ideas, checking grammar, or improving the clarity of your writing. However, you **may not use AI to generate substantive content that you submit as your own original work**. All assignments, essays, and projects must reflect your own analysis, critical thinking, and voice.

### Permitted Uses of AI:

- Outlining or organizing your thoughts
- Checking grammar, spelling, or clarity
- Generating ideas or prompts to help you get started
- Reviewing your own drafts for readability

### Prohibited Uses of AI:

- Submitting AI-generated essays, paragraphs, or answers as your own work
- Using AI to complete assignments, discussion posts, or projects in place of your own effort
- Copying and pasting AI-generated content without substantial revision and personal input

If you use AI tools in your process, you must **disclose** how you used them in a brief note at the end of your assignment (e.g., “I used ChatGPT to help brainstorm ideas for my outline.”).

### Violations:

Submitting AI-generated content as your own is considered academic dishonesty and will be treated as a violation of the university's academic integrity policy.

If you have questions about what is or is not allowed, please ask before submitting your work.

## 14 Representation Statement

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I am committed to including a broad range of perspectives in the readings and materials for this course. If you believe a critical voice is missing, please let me know so I can improve the syllabus now and in future offerings.

**We must treat every individual with respect.** We come from many different backgrounds, and this variety of viewpoints is fundamental to building and maintaining an equitable and inclusive campus community. “Representation” can refer to the ways we identify ourselves—race, color, national origin, language, sex, disability, age, sexual orientation, gender identity, religion, creed, ancestry, belief, veteran status, or genetic information, among others. Each of these identities shapes the perspectives our students, faculty, and staff bring to campus. Promoting these varied viewpoints not only fuels excellence and innovation but also advances the pursuit of justice. We acknowledge our imperfections while fully committing to the work—inside and outside our classrooms—of building and sustaining a campus community that embraces these core values.

Each of us is responsible for creating a safer, more inclusive environment.

Unfortunately, incidents of bias or discrimination do occur, whether intentional or unintentional. They contribute to an unwelcoming atmosphere for individuals and groups at the university. Therefore, the university encourages anyone who experiences or observes unfair or hostile treatment on the basis of identity to speak out for justice and seek support—either in the moment or afterward. You can share your experiences using the following resources:

- **Ethics Reporting Hotline**

Submit an anonymous report by calling 844-587-0793 or visiting **[cmu.ethicspoint.com](https://cmu.ethicspoint.com)**.

All reports are documented and reviewed to determine whether further action is needed. Regardless of the incident type, the university will use your feedback to transform our campus climate into one that is more equitable and just.

## 15 Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

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If you have a documented disability and an accommodations letter from the Office of Disability Resources, please discuss your needs with me as early in the semester as possible. I will work with you to ensure that accommodations are provided as appropriate. If you suspect you may have a disability and are not yet registered with the Office of Disability Resources, you can contact them at **[access@andrew.cmu.edu](mailto:access@andrew.cmu.edu)**.

## 16 Student Well-Being

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The past few years have been challenging. We are all under significant stress and uncertainty. I encourage you to find ways to move regularly, eat well, and reach out to your support system—or to me at **cervas@cmu.edu**—if you need help. We can all benefit from support during stressful times, and this semester is no exception.

As a student, you may experience a range of challenges that interfere with learning, such as strained relationships, increased anxiety, substance use, feeling down, difficulty concentrating, or lack of motivation. These mental health concerns or stressful events can diminish your academic performance and reduce your ability to participate in daily activities. CMU offers services that can help, and treatment does work. Learn more about confidential mental health services available on campus at:

- **Counseling and Psychological Services:** <http://www.cmu.edu/counseling/>  
Phone (24/7): 412-268-2922

Please remember that support is always available—don't hesitate to reach out.

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